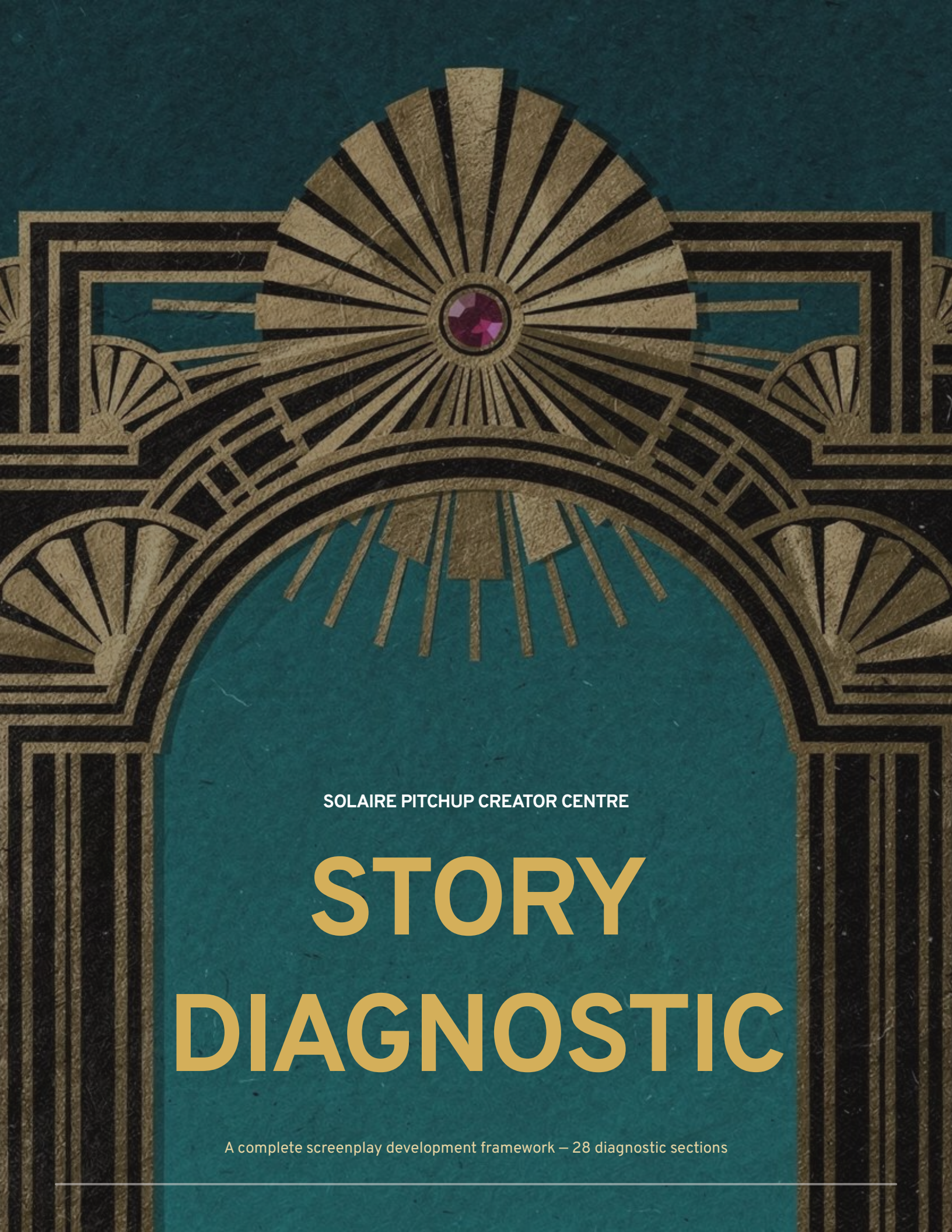


SOLAIRE PITCHUP CREATOR CENTRE

STORY DIAGNOSTIC

A complete screenplay development framework — 28 diagnostic sections

01

THE CORE STORY

Can the central premise be explained clearly and compellingly? What is the story really about? Who is it about? What do they want? What stands in their way? What happens if they fail? Is there a strong central dramatic question? Is the premise capable of sustaining the intended running time or series format? What is distinctive about this particular execution?

The Premise

- Can the central premise be explained clearly and compellingly?
- What is the story really about?
- Who is it about?
- What do they want?

The Stakes

- What stands in their way?
- What happens if they fail?
- Is there a strong central dramatic question?

Sustainability & Distinction

- Is the premise capable of sustaining the intended running time or series format?
- What is distinctive about this particular execution?



02

PROTAGONIST & AUDIENCE INVESTMENT

Do we care what happens to the protagonist? Why? What makes them compelling, fascinating, sympathetic, entertaining or emotionally recognisable? What do they want externally? What do they need internally? What are they afraid of? What contradiction makes them interesting? Are they actively driving events or merely responding to the plot? Do their choices have consequences? Would the audience miss them if they disappeared from the story?

Audience Connection

- Do we care what happens to the protagonist? Why?
- What makes them compelling, fascinating, sympathetic, entertaining or emotionally recognisable?
- Would the audience miss them if they disappeared from the story?

Internal vs External Drive

- What do they want externally?
- What do they need internally?
- What are they afraid of?
- What contradiction makes them interesting?

Agency & Consequence

- Are they actively driving events or merely responding to the plot?
- Do their choices have consequences?





03

CHARACTER OBJECTIVES, AGENCY & ARCS

Audit every significant character. What does each person want? Why do they want it? What are they prepared to do to obtain it? What are they hiding? What do they misunderstand about themselves or others? Do supporting characters have objectives independent of the protagonist? Are characters making decisions that alter the story? Do relationships and loyalties change under pressure? By the end, who has changed, who has refused to change and what has that cost them?

1

Character Wants & Motivations

- What does each person want?
- Why do they want it?
- What are they prepared to do to obtain it?

2

Hidden Dimensions

- What are they hiding?
- What do they misunderstand about themselves or others?

3

Supporting Characters

- Do supporting characters have objectives independent of the protagonist?

4

Change & Consequence

- Are characters making decisions that alter the story?
- Do relationships and loyalties change under pressure?
- By the end, who has changed, who has refused to change and what has that cost them?

04

CHARACTER VOICE & INDIVIDUALITY

Could you identify the speaker if the character names were removed from the dialogue? Consider age, education, profession, class, culture, nationality, vocabulary, vernacular, accent, rhythm and confidence. Do they speak precisely, expansively, bluntly, elliptically or formally? Do they swear, interrupt, ramble, hesitate, mispronounce, self-correct or repeat themselves? Do they have selective verbal habits such as "um", "like", "you know" or particular expressions? How does their speech change according to whom they are addressing? Flag dialogue that could be transferred between characters without anybody noticing.

THE NAMELESS DIALOGUE TEST

- Remove character names from an exchange. Within a few lines, could a reader still identify the speakers from vocabulary, rhythm, attitude and verbal behaviour? If several characters become interchangeable, their voices require greater differentiation.

AI CHECK

- Do not polish every character into the same grammatically perfect voice. Preserve purposeful differences in vocabulary, rhythm, education, culture and personality.





05

FEMALE CHARACTERS & STEREOTYPE AUDIT

Audit every significant female character independently. Does she have objectives, expertise, judgement, desires, flaws, humour and contradictions of her own? Does she make consequential decisions? Does she exist beyond her relationship to a male character? Is she disproportionately passive, frightened, emotionally fragile, easily led or dependent without a story-specific reason? Is she reduced to a familiar function: mother, nagging wife, victim, dutiful daughter, seductress, prostitute, moral conscience, helpless ingenue or emotional support system?

Check older women particularly. Are they allowed ambition, sexuality, authority, humour, selfishness, expertise and relevance?

Do not solve stereotyping simply by making women aggressive, invulnerable or conventionally "strong". Test whether female characters receive the same specificity, agency, complexity and narrative consequence as comparable male characters.

AI CHECK

Flag gendered assumptions that appear to arise from generic writing rather than deliberate characterisation.

06

ANTAGONISM, CONFLICT & PRESSURE

Who or what opposes the protagonist? Is the opposition intelligent and formidable? Does the antagonist have comprehensible motives rather than simply functioning as an obstacle? Are characters forced to make difficult choices? Does pressure increase? Do solutions create new problems? Are obstacles varied, or does the screenplay repeatedly generate the same kind of conflict?

1

The Opposition

- Who or what opposes the protagonist?
- Is the opposition intelligent and formidable?
- Does the antagonist have comprehensible motives rather than simply functioning as an obstacle?

2

Pressure & Choice

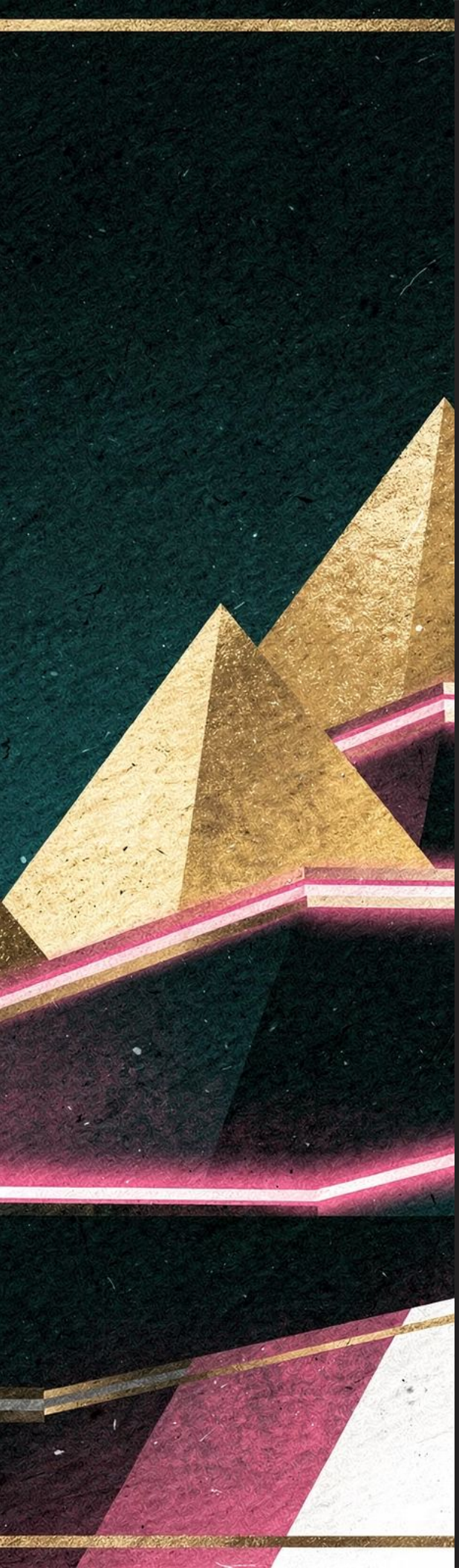
- Are characters forced to make difficult choices?
- Does pressure increase?
- Do solutions create new problems?

3

Conflict Variety

- Are obstacles varied, or does the screenplay repeatedly generate the same kind of conflict?





07

STAKES & ESCALATION

What happens if the protagonist fails? Are the stakes emotional and personal as well as external? Do they become progressively more consequential? Is something important at risk early enough? Are there moments when apparent success creates greater danger? Does the audience understand what can be lost without characters repeatedly explaining it?

1

Defining the Stakes

- What happens if the protagonist fails?
- Are the stakes emotional and personal as well as external?
- Is something important at risk early enough?

2

Escalation

- Do they become progressively more consequential?
- Are there moments when apparent success creates greater danger?

3

Audience Understanding

- Does the audience understand what can be lost without characters repeatedly explaining it?

08

STRUCTURE & TURNING POINTS

Map the major movements of the story. What launches it? What commits the protagonist to the central journey? Where does the story materially change direction? What happens around the midpoint? Does the midpoint create a meaningful reversal, revelation, victory, defeat or escalation rather than merely occurring halfway through the page count? Where are the major highs and lows? What forces the final confrontation? Does the climax arise from decisions and consequences established earlier?

Use structural models such as three-act structure, five-act structure, Hero's Journey or another appropriate framework only where useful to the particular story. Do not distort a screenplay merely to satisfy a prescribed formula.

1

Story Launch & Commitment

- What launches it?
- What commits the protagonist to the central journey?

2

Midpoint & Direction

- Where does the story materially change direction?
- What happens around the midpoint?
- Does the midpoint create a meaningful reversal, revelation, victory, defeat or escalation rather than merely occurring halfway through the page count?
- Where are the major highs and lows?

3

Climax & Resolution

- What forces the final confrontation?
- Does the climax arise from decisions and consequences established earlier?



09

THE MIDPOINT TEST

At approximately the centre of the story, has something genuinely changed? Does the protagonist gain important knowledge, suffer a reversal, achieve an apparent victory, experience a significant loss, change strategy or become more deeply committed? Are the stakes different after the midpoint than before it? If the second half could proceed exactly as it would without the midpoint event, the midpoint may not be doing enough work.

Genuine Change?

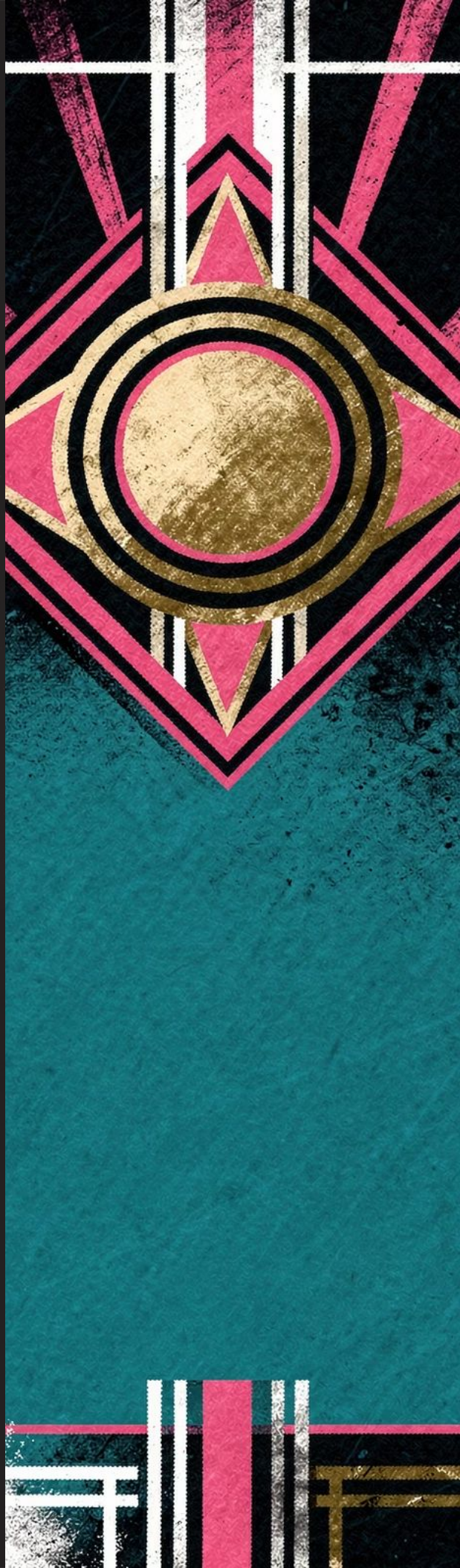
Does the protagonist gain important knowledge, suffer a reversal, achieve an apparent victory, experience a significant loss, change strategy or become more deeply committed?

Stakes Shift?

Are the stakes different after the midpoint than before it?

Midpoint Impact?

If the second half could proceed exactly as it would without the midpoint event, the midpoint may not be doing enough work.



10

SCENE PURPOSE & ENTRY/EXIT POINTS

For every scene ask: why does this scene exist? Who wants what? What prevents them getting it? What changes between the beginning and end? Does the scene reveal character, advance plot, alter a relationship, provide essential information or preferably accomplish several functions simultaneously? Could the scene disappear without damaging the story? Does it repeat information, conflict or an emotional beat already established?

ENTER LATE, LEAVE EARLY

Where does the scene actually begin - the first line carrying dramatic content, or an earlier line of arrival, greeting or setup that could be cut? Where does it end - the moment its dramatic question is answered, or does it continue past that point? Flag scenes that open with characters arriving, sitting down or exchanging pleasantries before the real business starts. Flag scenes that linger after the beat has landed.

THE LAST 10% TEST

Is the final beat doing new work, changing our understanding or creating forward momentum, or merely confirming what the audience already understood?

THE WHO'S WATCHING TEST

In scenes with more than two characters, what is every person present doing dramatically? Flag characters who remain present without purpose.



THE TURN-THE-PAGE TEST

At the end of every significant scene or sequence ask:

Why would I keep watching?

What question has just been answered? What new question has been created? What remains unresolved? What danger, mystery, desire, revelation, emotional tension or anticipated event pulls us forward?

A scene does not always need a cliffhanger. It should usually alter our understanding, expectations or anticipation. Flag stretches in which the audience has no compelling reason to discover what happens next.

The Forward Pull

- What question has just been answered?
- What new question has been created?
- What remains unresolved?
- What danger, mystery, desire, revelation, emotional tension or anticipated event pulls us forward?

Scene Impact

A scene does not always need a cliffhanger. It should usually alter our understanding, expectations or anticipation.

Flag stretches in which the audience has no compelling reason to discover what happens next.



QUESTIONS, ANSWERS & INFORMATION FLOW

Track the questions the screenplay creates. When is each answered? Does answering one important question generate another? Are mysteries withheld fairly, with sufficient information for the audience to remain engaged? Are answers delayed because of genuine dramatic circumstances rather than artificial concealment? Is crucial information revealed too early? Are there forgotten questions that never receive a payoff?

The audience should experience a controlled rhythm of

question → partial answer → consequence → new question

THE ABSENT SCENE TEST

Examine transitions between consecutive scenes. What must the audience infer happened between them? If nothing needs to be inferred because every connective action has been shown, the screenplay may be over-explaining. If essential developments appear to have occurred without sufficient preparation, there may be a missing scene or story beat.



REVELATION, SECRETS & DRAMATIC IRONY

What does the audience know that the characters do not? What does one character know that another does not? Where are secrets creating tension? Are revelations arriving at the most dramatically effective moment? Could information become more powerful by changing who discovers it, when they discover it or whether the audience knows first?

Audience vs Character Knowledge

- What does the audience know that the characters do not?
- What does one character know that another does not?

Secrets & Tension

- Where are secrets creating tension?

Revelation Timing

- Are revelations arriving at the most dramatically effective moment?
- Could information become more powerful by changing who discovers it, when they discover it or whether the audience knows first?



14

PLANTING & PAYOFF

Identify significant objects, behaviours, information, promises, relationships, skills and mysteries introduced during the screenplay. Which return later? Are important resolutions properly prepared? Does an apparently insignificant detail acquire meaning later? Flag forgotten plants, unearned payoffs, convenient solutions and set-ups that never become dramatically useful.

What Has Been Planted?

- What significant objects, behaviours, information, promises, relationships, skills, or mysteries have been introduced?
- Which of these return later in the story?
- Does an apparently insignificant detail acquire meaning later?

Payoff & Resolution

- Are important resolutions properly prepared?

Red Flags

- Are there forgotten plants or unearned payoffs?
- Are there convenient solutions or set-ups that never become dramatically useful?



15

DIALOGUE & SUBTEXT

Does dialogue accomplish more than exchanging information? Are characters explaining things they already know? Are they describing what the audience can see? Are they stating their emotions rather than behaving them? Do characters always answer questions directly? Where are they lying, evading, provoking, manipulating, concealing, testing or protecting themselves? What is being communicated underneath the literal words?

EXPOSITION OWNERSHIP TEST

Whenever a character delivers exposition, ask why that character wants to say it at that moment. Are they trying to persuade, conceal, impress, intimidate, manipulate, wound, reassure or achieve something? If their only function is to provide information to the audience, flag the dialogue.



PACING, RHYTHM & TONAL VARIATION

Map the emotional and dramatic temperature of consecutive scenes. Does the screenplay remain in one register for too long? After sustained tension, is there space for humour, intimacy, stillness or release? After quieter material, does something restore momentum? Are action, suspense, comedy, tenderness, discomfort, mystery and reflection varied appropriately for this particular story?

Do not manufacture arbitrary tonal changes. Look for contrast and rhythm. A relentlessly melancholy screenplay can become emotionally flat; relentless action can become equally monotonous. Contrast allows individual moments to have greater impact.

Tonal Register

- Does the screenplay remain in one register for too long?
- After sustained tension, is there space for humour, intimacy, stillness or release?
- After quieter material, does something restore momentum?
- Are action, suspense, comedy, tenderness, discomfort, mystery and reflection varied appropriately for this particular story?

Contrast & Rhythm

- Do not manufacture arbitrary tonal changes.
- Look for contrast and rhythm.
- A relentlessly melancholy screenplay can become emotionally flat; relentless action can become equally monotonous.
- Contrast allows individual moments to have greater impact.



EMOTIONAL JOURNEY

Map what the audience should feel throughout the screenplay. Where should we laugh, fear, hope, worry, grieve, become angry, feel tenderness, experience relief or anticipate disaster? Are there prolonged emotionally neutral sections? Do emotional peaks build appropriately? Has the screenplay earned its most important emotional moments?

Emotional Mapping

- Map what the audience should feel throughout the screenplay.
- Where should we laugh, fear, hope, worry, grieve, become angry, feel tenderness, experience relief or anticipate disaster?

Peaks & Neutrality

- Are there prolonged emotionally neutral sections?
- Do emotional peaks build appropriately?

Earned Moments

- Has the screenplay earned its most important emotional moments?



THEME

What is the story ultimately examining beneath its plot? Is the theme emerging through characters, choices, consequences and conflict, or are characters delivering the writer's argument? Do different characters embody genuinely different perspectives? Does the screenplay allow difficult ideas to remain complicated? Does the ending deepen or resolve the thematic question?

The Underlying Question

- What is the story ultimately examining beneath its plot?

How Theme Emerges

- Is the theme emerging through characters, choices, consequences and conflict, or are characters delivering the writer's argument?
- Do different characters embody genuinely different perspectives?

Complexity & Resolution

- Does the screenplay allow difficult ideas to remain complicated?
- Does the ending deepen or resolve the thematic question?



ORIGINALITY & PREDICTABILITY

What have audiences seen before? What makes this version distinctive? Are familiar genre conventions being used deliberately? Can the audience predict major developments too easily? Are twists surprising but retrospectively logical? Does the project contain characters, relationships, imagery, situations or ideas that could become uniquely associated with it?

Distinctiveness

- What makes this version distinctive?
- Does the project contain characters, relationships, imagery, situations or ideas that could become uniquely associated with it?

Genre & Convention

- What have audiences seen before?
- Are familiar genre conventions being used deliberately?

Surprise & Logic

- Can the audience predict major developments too easily?
- Are twists surprising but retrospectively logical?



SCREENPLAY ECONOMY

Flag unnecessary scenes, redundant characters, repeated information, repeated emotional beats, excessive exposition, overwritten action, unnecessary adjectives, unfilmable internal thoughts and dialogue explaining what the audience already understands.

Ask repeatedly: If this disappears, what does the story lose?

If the answer is "nothing", consider removing it.

Identifying Excess

- Unnecessary scenes
- Redundant characters
- Repeated information or emotional beats
- Excessive exposition
- Overwritten action or adjectives
- Unfilmable internal thoughts
- Dialogue explaining what the audience already understands

The Economy Test

If something in your story disappears, does the narrative lose anything essential?

If the answer is **"nothing"**, it's likely a candidate for removal to streamline the storytelling.



THE ENDING

Does the climax arise from the protagonist's actions and choices? Does it confront the central dramatic problem? Are important character and relationship arcs resolved appropriately? Are major plants paid off? Does the ending answer enough questions to satisfy while preserving deliberate ambiguity where appropriate? Is the final emotional impression the one the writer intends?

For series: does the episode or season satisfy its immediate dramatic promise while creating genuine desire for what follows?

Climax & Resolution

- Does the climax arise from the protagonist's actions and choices?
- Does it confront the central dramatic problem?
- Does the ending answer enough questions to satisfy while preserving deliberate ambiguity where appropriate?
- Is the final emotional impression the one the writer intends?

Arcs & Payoffs

- Are important character and relationship arcs resolved appropriately?
- Are major plants paid off?

Series Considerations

Does the episode or season satisfy its immediate dramatic promise while creating genuine desire for what follows?



FORMAT & GENRE TEST

Does the story deliver what its chosen genre promises while retaining individuality? Does a thriller generate suspense? Does comedy actually produce comic situations? Does horror create fear or unease? Does a mystery provide a satisfying investigative engine? For television, is there a renewable series engine beyond the pilot? For features, does the premise justify its running time?

Genre Delivery

- Does the story deliver what its chosen genre promises while retaining individuality?
- Does a thriller generate suspense?
- Does comedy actually produce comic situations?
- Does horror create fear or unease?
- Does a mystery provide a satisfying investigative engine?

Format Considerations

- For television, is there a renewable series engine beyond the pilot?
- For features, does the premise justify its running time?



AI WRITING AUDIT

Check specifically for patterns commonly introduced or amplified by generative AI: characters with suspiciously similar voices; excessive emotional explanation; generic vulnerability; repetitive sentence structures; unnecessary adjectives; characters constantly smirking, sighing or exchanging knowing looks; overuse of exposition; artificial symmetry; repeated thematic statements; generic "strong female character" behaviour; scenes that sound polished but contain little dramatic movement.

AI should identify these patterns. It should not automatically rewrite the writer's voice.

Identifying AI Patterns

- Characters with suspiciously similar voices
- Excessive emotional explanation; generic vulnerability
- Repetitive sentence structures; unnecessary adjectives
- Characters constantly smirking, sighing or exchanging knowing looks
- Overuse of exposition; artificial symmetry
- Repeated thematic statements; generic "strong female character" behaviour
- Scenes that sound polished but contain little dramatic movement

The AI's Role

AI should identify these patterns. It should not automatically rewrite the writer's voice.



PRODUCER'S EYE

Now forget the individual rules and assess the screenplay as an industry reader.

Would you read beyond page 10? Where did your attention first wander? Which character would you most want to cast? What is the strongest selling point? What is the weakest element? What would concern a producer, commissioner, financier or distributor? What would make somebody describe this project to another person tomorrow? If you could fix only three things before submitting it, what would they be?

First Impressions

- Would you read beyond page 10?
- Where did your attention first wander?

Industry Assessment

- Which character would you most want to cast?
- What is the strongest selling point?
- What is the weakest element?
- What would concern a producer, commissioner, financier or distributor?

The Pitch

- What would make somebody describe this project to another person tomorrow?
- If you could fix only three things before submitting it, what would they be?

THE ONE CLEAR IMAGE TEST

After reading, can you immediately recall one image, moment, situation or piece of dramatic business distinctive enough to describe to somebody else and make them curious? If nothing comes readily to mind, examine whether the screenplay has a sufficiently memorable dramatic or visual identity.





STORY DIAGNOSTIC SCORECARD

Score each relevant category out of 10. Weight protagonist/audience investment, story engine, stakes, character agency, scene propulsion, structure and emotional engagement most heavily.

OVERALL PITCHUP STORY SCORE: /100

GREEN — WORKING

Strong. Protect it unless another revision affects it.

AMBER — NEEDS ATTENTION

A weakness worth examining before submission.

RED — STRUCTURAL PROBLEM

Likely to damage audience engagement or industry readiness.

For every Amber or Red assessment, identify: **WHERE** the problem occurs; **WHY** it matters; **WHAT QUESTION** the writer should ask to solve it. Do not prescribe a replacement scene unless specifically asked.

REVISION PRIORITIES

Do not overwhelm the writer with fifty recommendations. Rank findings:

1

4. POLISH — FIX LAST

word economy, description, formatting and minor dialogue refinement.

2

3. SCENE LEVEL — FIX THIRD

scene purpose, dialogue, exposition, repetition and tonal rhythm.

3

2. DEVELOPMENTAL — FIX SECOND

relationships, pacing, revelations, emotional journey, planting and payoff.

4

1. STRUCTURAL — FIX FIRST

premise, protagonist, stakes, structure, agency or ending.

Before producing priorities, run these final checks: **Enter Late, Leave Early**; **Last 10%**; **Who's Watching**; **Nameless Dialogue**; **Exposition Ownership**; **Absent Scene**; **Turn-the-Page**; **One Clear Image**.

Identify the five changes most likely to improve the screenplay, in priority order. Only elevate a finding if fixing it would materially improve the screenplay.



REVISE. RETEST. COMPARE.

The diagnostic is a development tool, not a substitute for authorship. Make deliberate revisions, then run the screenplay through the same assessment again. Compare the scores. What genuinely improved? What became weaker? Did solving one problem create another? Has the writer's distinctive voice survived the revision?

A higher numerical score is useful only when the screenplay itself has become better.



READY FOR PITCHUP?

Once the screenplay is working, move to the PitchUp Readiness assessment and Pitch Package.

The objective is not a screenplay engineered to obey every screenwriting rule. The objective is a story that holds attention, creates emotional investment, continually generates anticipation and feels as though only this writer could have written it.